Sulfate Tablet Prep

Colonoscopy prep · Kurt Vernon, MD, PA

Procedure date: _____ **Arrival time:** _____

Procedure time: _____ **Stop all liquids at (office fills in):** _____

Buy at the Pharmacy

- ✓ Your sulfate tablet prep kit (prescription): two bottles of 12 tablets and a 16-ounce cup. Throw away the small moisture packet in each bottle. Never swallow it.
- ✓ Drinking water

Before Your Prep Day

1. At least 7 days before: read the Medication instructions before colonoscopy. Get a written plan from the office for any blood thinner, insulin or other diabetes medicine. Don't stop a prescribed blood thinner on your own.
2. 7 days before: stop non-aspirin NSAIDs (such as ibuprofen, naproxen or meloxicam), GLP-1 medicines (such as semaglutide or tirzepatide), phentermine and any recreational drugs, as the medication instructions explain.
3. 4 days before: stop SGLT2 medicines (such as empagliflozin or dapagliflozin).
4. Keep taking baby aspirin (81 mg) unless you're given a different plan. If you take a different aspirin dose, call for instructions.
5. 2 days before: stop cannabis (48 hours before your procedure).
6. Tell us before you start if you have kidney disease, dialysis, heart failure, a fluid restriction, abnormal blood salts, pregnancy, severe constipation, a poor prep in the past, or trouble swallowing. Tell us about any recent urgent care or emergency room visits or hospital stays.
7. Don't start the prep if you have a known bowel blockage or perforation, or severe belly swelling with pain or vomiting. Call us instead.

The Day Before

1. Clear liquids only, the entire day. No solid food. Drink clear liquids all day and between doses, until your cutoff time.
2. If you have diabetes, follow your written plan. Don't cut your insulin in half or stop it on your own, and never stop all insulin if you have type 1 diabetes. Check your blood sugar during the day.
3. Take your routine pills at least 1 hour before each prep dose. Some medicines (certain antibiotics, iron, digoxin, chlorpromazine and penicillamine) need more time apart: ask your pharmacist for a written schedule. Read the Medication Guide that comes with your kit.
4. Both doses are taken the day before your procedure. This is Dr. Vernon's schedule, which differs from the schedule on the package.
5. **4:00 pm, first dose:** fill the cup with 16 ounces of water. Swallow one tablet every 1 to 2 minutes, and finish all 12 tablets and the water within about 20 minutes.
6. About 1 hour after the last tablet, drink another 16 ounces of water over 30 minutes. About 30 minutes after that, drink another 16 ounces of water over 30 minutes. That's 48 ounces of water for each dose.
7. **10:00 pm, second dose:** repeat all three steps with the second bottle of 12 tablets. Take all 24 tablets and all of the water. If you finish the tablets at 10:20 pm, drink the next 16 ounces at about 11:20 to 11:50 pm and the last 16 ounces at about 12:20 to 12:50 am.
8. If you feel sick to your stomach, bloated or crampy, slow down or pause the extra water until you feel better. Call if you can't finish before your cutoff time. No bisacodyl or other laxatives with this prep.

The Day of Your Colonoscopy

1. Stop ALL liquids, including water and prep, 3 hours before your procedure time, or earlier if anesthesia tells you to. For a 5:30 am procedure, that's 2:30 am. The office will write your exact time on your sheet.
2. No solid food. No smoking, vaping or chewing tobacco after midnight.
3. Take only the medicines you were told to take this morning, with a small sip of water.
4. Bring an adult who can drive you home after sedation. You can't drive yourself. Plan for someone to stay with you the rest of the day.
5. Bring your medication list, your inhaler, your CPAP if you were told to, and your diabetes supplies if you have diabetes.
6. Leave jewelry and valuables at home. Your colonoscopy is at our Fuquay-Varina Endoscopy Center.

Clear Liquids You Can Have

Nothing red, blue or purple. No alcohol, milk or milk products, smoothies, or juice with pulp.

- Water
- Clear broth or bouillon (no vegetables)
- Apple or white grape juice, without pulp
- Clear sports or electrolyte drinks
- Soft drinks, including colas
- Plain coffee or tea, without milk, cream or creamer
- Gelatin, without fruit
- Ice pops, without fruit or cream
- Hard candy

When to Call Us

Stay near a bathroom. Watery diarrhea is expected, and by the end it should be clear or pale yellow with no solid pieces. Call if it's still brown or solid, you can't finish the prep, you keep vomiting, or you miss a dose. Don't add another laxative on your own.

Get Help Right Away

Stop the prep and get urgent care for severe or lasting belly pain, rectal bleeding, fainting, or very little urine. **Call 911** for chest pain, trouble breathing, a seizure or passing out.

Can't make it? Call at least 48 hours ahead to reschedule. There is a $75 fee for a no-show, or for canceling with less than 48 hours' notice.

Questions about your prep? Call Fuquay-Varina at (919) 577-0085 or Dunn at (910) 891-5808, Monday – Thursday, 8:30 am – 5:00 pm.